

fears were never realized as their friendships survived their lifestyle changes. In fact, their friendships became stronger as their friends rallied to give them emotional support through this transitional period in their lives.

Realizing that nothing in life is a certainty is a great philosophy to maintain when confronted with income and expense fluctuations. Your reality now is the reality for the moment. This reality may change as events in your life change. How you respond to this change is your biggest challenge.

### **Shop 'Til You Drop**

At the beginning of this chapter, I said there were only two ways to improve your financial situation—increase your income or decrease your expenses. For the greatest improvement, do both. The following story showed me that for some people there is a third way.

A young woman named Veronique asked me for advice as to how she could make her financial situation better. She had graduated from Florida State University the previous year and had moved to Miami. She was now employed as an assistant to the director of sales for a large hotel. This position required working long hours and weekends, but unfortunately she never received overtime pay because she was paid straight salary. She once calculated what she made per hour and it was shockingly close to minimum wage (\$5.85 in summer 2007) after considering her average work week was sixty to seventy hours.

It is important to understand how much you actually earn after Federal taxes.

